Install the course software

UvA researchers' AI course 2026. Do this at home, before the first evening. It takes about 20 minutes.

Before you start

You need an internet connection, your normal user account, and a Claude account. The course email tells you which subscription to buy. Download the course files: go to **github.com/gstrezoski/uva-abs-ai-research-course-2026**, click the green **Code** button and choose **Download ZIP**. Keep the whole folder together, because the script needs the files next to it.

The script installs Git, Python 3.12, VS Code and Claude Code, then creates a **research-course** folder in your home folder with a Python environment and one folder per lab. Running it twice is safe. Anything already installed is skipped.

Windows 10 or 11

1. Right-click the downloaded zip and choose **Extract All**. The script will not run from inside the zip.

2. Open the extracted folder until you see **scripts**, and open that. Click the address bar at the top, type **powershell** and press Enter. PowerShell opens in that folder.

3. Start the setup. Approve the Windows prompts if they appear:

```
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\setup-windows.ps1
```

4. Wait for the green text **Setup finished**. Then close PowerShell, open a new one from the Start menu and check:

```
cd $HOME\research-course; .\.venv\Scripts\Activate.ps1; cd lab0-intro; claude
```

macOS

1. Double-click the downloaded zip if your browser did not unpack it already.

2. Press **Cmd + Space**, type **Terminal** and press Enter. Type **cd** and a space, drag the **scripts** folder from Finder onto the Terminal window, and press Enter.

3. Start the setup. It does not ask for your password:

```
bash setup-mac.sh
```

4. If a window asks to install the **Command Line Tools**, click Install. Wait for the green text **Setup finished**. Then close Terminal, open a new one and check:

```
cd ~/research-course && source .venv/bin/activate && cd lab0-intro && claude
```

The first time you type claude

Claude Code opens a browser window. Log in with your Claude account and go back to the terminal. If you see a prompt waiting for you, you are ready for the first evening.

If something goes wrong

Run the script again first, since it picks up where it stopped. If it still fails, take a screenshot of the last lines in red or yellow and send it to the course team. A few machines always need help, especially UvA-managed laptops. We sort those out before the course, and on the night you can work in pairs.

On Windows, if **Activate.ps1** is blocked, run `Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope CurrentUser RemoteSigned` once and try again. On a Mac, if **claude** or **code** is not found, close every Terminal window and open a new one.

To remove everything later, run **teardown-windows.ps1** the same way as the setup, or **bash teardown-mac.sh**, from the same scripts folder. It deletes the research-course folder, so copy out your work first.